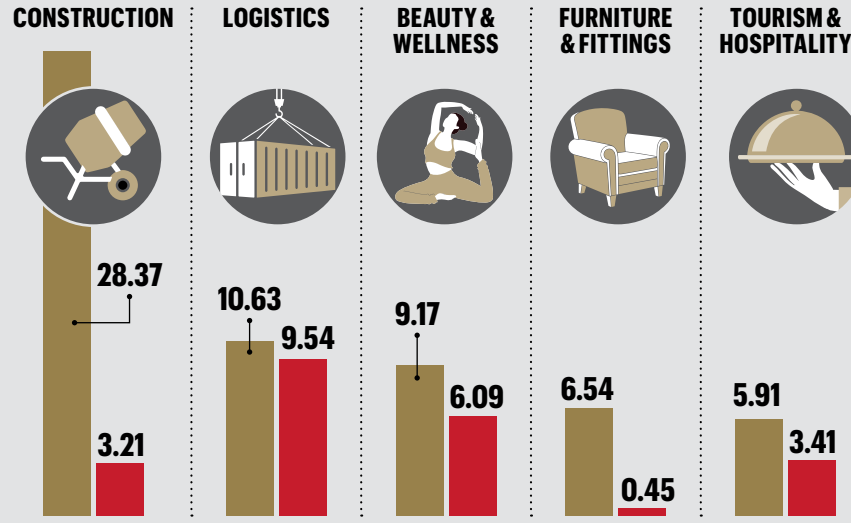
courses at empanelled centres—typically 200-600 hours and up to six months—targeted at school and college dropouts and the unemployed. Then, there is Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL), which upskills the workforce through bridge courses at online/ offline camps, employers' premises, etc. The third are Special Projects (SPs), which target vulnerable groups or specialised industries.

Across the first three phases, the total outlay stood at Rs 14,449 crore. Of this, Rs 10,194 crore was released and Rs 9,261 crore utilised. Of the target of 13.2 million candidates, 11 million were certified on clearing the post-training third-party assessment—an 83 per cent achievement rate on paper. Yet placement—the scheme's key desired outcome—also remains one of its most persistent challenges. According to the CAG, only 223,000, or 16.7 per cent, of the 1.33 million fresh candidates certified under STT/ SP during PMKVY 1.0 secured jobs. Placement rates improved to 51.1 per cent under PMKVY 2.0 before falling again to 13.5 per cent under PMKVY 3.0.

DEMAND-SUPPLY MISMATCH

PMKVY trainings were not in sync with the job market. Construction accounted for over 28 per cent of workforce demand but got just 3.2 per cent of certified candidates. Conversely, sectors such as electronics and apparel got far more trainees despite low demand



Source: CAG report on 'Skill Development under PMKVY'



"FOR TRAINING PARTNERS OPERATING IN THE DEEP INTERIORS OF BIHAR OR THE NORTHEAST, PLACEMENTS ARE CHALLENGING DUE TO THE LIMITED INDUSTRIAL PRESENCE"

– R.C.M. REDDY, MD & CEO, Learnet Skills

SCALE BEFORE SYSTEMS

The ministry of skill development and entrepreneurship (MSDE), set up in November 2014, had limited manpower when its flagship scheme, PMKVY, was launched the following year. NSDC, the central agency responsible for the scheme's end-to-end implementation, also had to start from scratch in building capacity across states to oversee a programme as ambitious as PMKVY. That essential coordination with states took time and, hence, the ability to implement the scheme on a large scale lagged in the early years, with limited oversight from MSDE.

A former MSDE official, speaking to INDIA TODAY on condition of anonymity, attributes many early shortcomings to the fact that NSDC had scanty state-level presence. "They had only around 40–45 on-ground staff across all states, which made monitoring extremely difficult," he reveals. At the time, technology-enabled monitoring systems had yet to be introduced, leaving physical verification of training centres as the only oversight mechanism. In large states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, NSDC had only two or three staff members overseeing dozens of districts. "How can one person effectively cover 15-20 districts?" the official asks.

The regulatory architecture also came up late. As the CAG report notes, the National Council for Vocational Education and Training (NCVET)—the sector's regulator—was established only in 2018, and it took till April 2021 before its members assumed full-time charge. By then, PMKVY had already run for several years.

The scheme itself unfolded in phases. PMKVY 1.0 was launched for one year in 2015–16. The programme was scaled up under PMKVY 2.0, which ran from 2016 to 2020 and was later extended until January 2021. PMKVY 3.0 followed, covering the 2021–22 period. Each phase introduced design changes, often while training was already under way. New technology layers were added midstream, complicating implementation. At the time, India Stack—i.e. the unified digital public infrastructure, from Aadhaar to UPI and DigiLocker—was still being built, explains a former NSDC employee, requesting anonymity. "The systems were nascent," she adds, "and we had to ensure that backend portals for monitoring, training providers, trainee data,